

Illinois courts track criminal charges using an offense code table that links each charge to the law that defines it. However, the offense descriptions are often too brief to be informative, while the underlying legal text is long and technical, making it difficult for non-lawyers to interpret. This creates a need for plain-English summaries that present the meaning of each offense in an accessible format.

Working with the Cook County Justice Advisory Council, the team set out to generate readable summaries of over 2,000 high-priority offenses. Because manually writing summaries at this scale would be impractical, the team built an automated pipeline. As Figure 1 illustrates, a lengthy legal text was compressed into concise summaries that capture each offense's key elements. A quality check then flagged errors such as inaccurate details and statute mismatches, which were systematically corrected.

Building on these summaries, the team mapped each offense to a federal crime category, enabling analysts to track broad trends across jurisdictions. The result is a dataset linking Illinois offense codes to readable descriptions and standardized categories, supporting prosecutors, public defenders, and policy researchers in conducting previously impractical comparisons. The summaries also provide a standardized representation that can support further analysis.

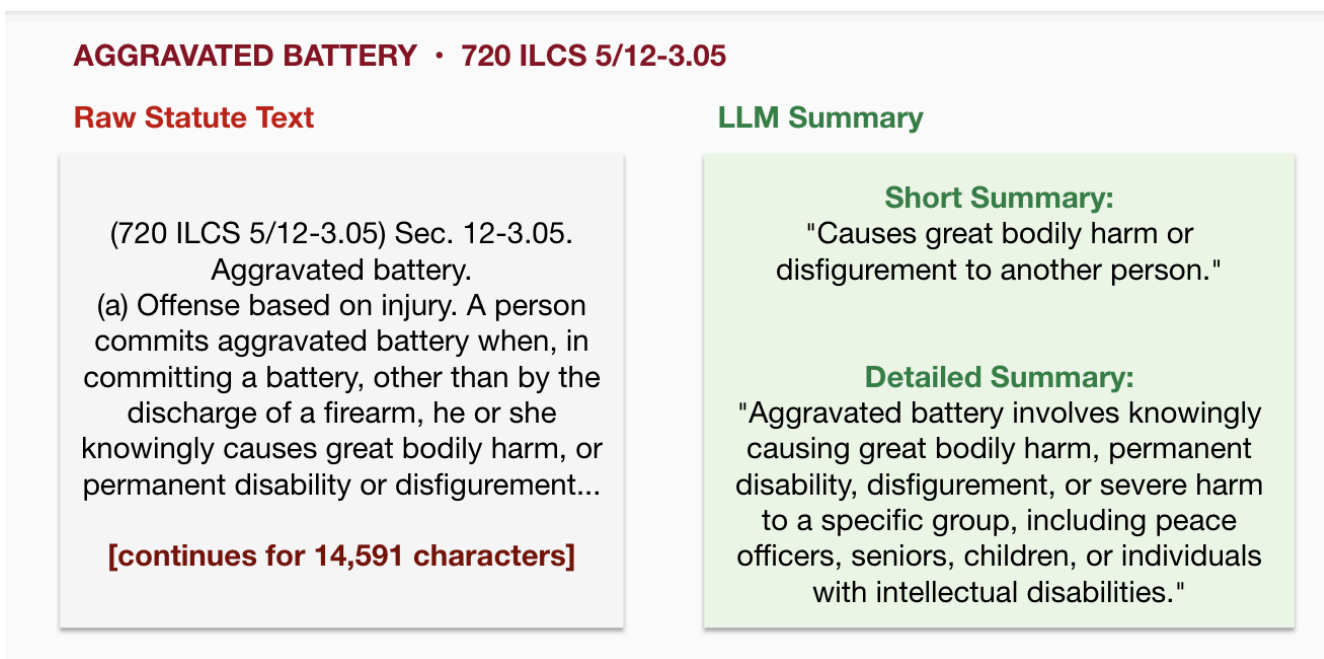


Figure 1. A lengthy statute (left) compressed into a concise plain-English summary (right).